

Author's note: I'm going to give away the ending to this one right up front because the simple fact is that there is no ending. As you'll see, this story is loosely based on real-life events. My purpose here is only to introduce the storyline and show the initial reactions of all involved. But life has not yet written the ending. Early signs are good, but there's no telling where it's ultimately going to go.

I will say this: deciding to introduce this angle wasn't something I did on a whim. In fact, I'm still not completely sure I should have taken it on at all. But I recently expressed a desire to get away from the big, 50+ chapter stories for a little while. I want to write a little more about the everyday, and this, unfortunately, is a thing that many people have to face up to... every day.

-1- So Easily Lost

Life is good, I thought to myself as I slipped a powder blue cotton sweater over my head and stepped into the bathroom.

Rampage Sports, Incorporated - the women's MMA stable I own and try desperately not to screw up - was humming along on a level I never could have imagined. That's not just my feeling. It is now a proven fact. The most recent league tournament started with two hundred and fifty-six fighters, divided evenly into eight weight classes, with each weight class producing a single champion.

There are over thirty stables in the league. Many of the them much larger than *Rampage*. And yet, we produced five of the eight champions.

How did we achieve such a stunning result? Well, the truth is, we're not entirely sure. There's been a lot going on these past months. Veterans in crisis. Rookies going astray. Things that knocked us out of our normal day-to-day groove and left us feeling like we could tip into a full-blown disaster at any moment.

Instead, it all led to a whole new way of doing things. One that isn't exactly organized or strategic, but somehow feels more intrinsic and natural.

One of the things I've always understood is that, for this stable thing to work, it has to be about more than just fighting. I come from a background where the only person I could rely on was me. I made it work pretty well, but it's not an approach I'd recommend if there are other options. That's my goal with RSI. To make those other options - *better* options - available. No one here has to go it alone. If someone needs me, I'm here to help. If I can't do it, then Stable Leader Danneel Harris can step in. Or Fighter Development Coordinator, Steph McMahon. There is always someone available to lend a hand.

Or, at least, there usually is.

The run up to the tournament put a strain on us like none we'd ever experienced before. With so much going on, the established leadership didn't hold. Danni, Steph and I were being yanked in every direction... and yet, the group kept on. Without ever being asked, others stepped up to fill the void. All throughout the stable, a new approach took hold. Hard work and preparation were obviously still major components, and opponent-specific

game-planning remained essential. But the glue that held it all together was more about relationships and camaraderie than training plans and rigid routine. The women here had become a kind of family, and they figured out how to be there for each other.

It sounds a little weird, but the results... well, they speak for themselves. And the fact is that it doesn't look all that strange when you watch it happen. Established champions are pushing each other to become better. Rookies are hooking up with veterans to tap into their experience and learn new techniques... and the seasoned fighters are even learning a thing or two from their younger counterparts. When it comes down to it, everything is working about as well as I could hope.

The thing is, not knowing exactly why it's all working so well leaves me wondering what we need to do to keep it going.

I have, however, identified one key factor. One person whose influence is an absolute must.

"I don't understand," Danni said defensively. "Why do you need to take over my duties?"

I stood in front of the mirror and pulled a brush through my auburn hair.

"I'm not taking over anything," I said. "I'm simply lightening your load a little."

"You're not happy with the way I'm doing things?"

I gathered my hair in a high ponytail, slid on a hair band and stepped back out into the bedroom.

"That may be the dumbest thing I've ever heard come out of your mouth," I said. "How long have we been doing this? You don't think I'd have said something by now if I had a problem?"

Danni has been the Stable Leader of *Rampage Sports* since the day I opened the doors, and I've never regretted that decision for an instant. She is everything I could have hoped for, and a whole lot of things I never even thought about. She's genuinely invested in giving each fighter exactly what she needs to reach whatever goal is next. Committed and determined in the gym, she sets the standard for the rest of the group. Oh, and it probably doesn't hurt that she is supremely talented in the cage. She was a long-reigning champion when I hired her, and she's only gotten better since.

Exactly how good is she? Well, it's a big league with a lot of divisions, and determining the pound-for-pound queen is a never-ending debate. But Danni's name is sure to come up in every conversation.

To say I was happy with her performance - both as a fighter and a leader - would be the mother of all understatements. The fact is, I don't have any clue how I got this lucky or where we would be without her.

"Then what's the problem?" she asked.

"There's no problem," I said. "I want to free you up to spend more time on the training floor. That's all."

"And why do I need to do that?"

She stepped over to the full length mirror, tugging at her blouse to adjust the fit.

"Because you are the straw that stirs the drink, my dear."

"Wow," she said, "what a load of crap."

I didn't argue because it was no use. Another thing to know about Danni is that she is humble to a level that is almost beyond human understanding. She treats everyone as an equal, even though her equal has yet to be found. From the greenest of rookies to the most decorated of champions, they all get the same level of respect from her - provided they respect her, as well. And nothing about it is fake or forced. I've come to believe that she really doesn't comprehend how good she is.

I pressed up close behind her, wrapping my arms around her waist as I put my chin on her shoulder and looked at the two of us in the mirror. I liked what I saw.

"Neither of us really knows what happened at the tournament," I said. "All we know is how it turned out."

"We already talked about this," she said. "What happened in Australia was special. If you think we can somehow recreate or recapture that, you're nuts."

"I know, and I'm not looking to bottle up any kind of secret formula. But we both know the reason things were so different last time."

She narrowed her eyes at me in the mirror.

"Oh, no, no," she said. "I don't need to be anyone's pet project, anymore. I'm good now, thanks."

Those veterans in crisis I mentioned? Well, Danni's name was at the head of that list. A rare loss cost her much more than her divisional crown. Because it wasn't just a loss. It was a disaster in which she was absolutely mauled by Cheryl Cole.

The reasons behind the poor performance are complicated, but the fact was that Danni wasn't ready for that fight... and I bear a lot of the responsibility for that. But none of that really matters. Fans and pundits don't talk about fighters' personal lives because they rightly don't care. That's not what they're here for. What matters to them is what they see in the cage, and on that night they saw Danni take a vicious, one-sided beating from one of her most talented rivals. Suddenly, a fighter who many counted among the best in the league was facing hard questions from every direction. What was she going to do now? Could she come back after such a terrible failure? Was she still good enough to even try, or was this the beginning of the end for her?

In typical fashion, Danni had very little to say. She admitted Cole had been clearly better, and she offered no excuses for her rare letdown. Meanwhile, Cheryl simply couldn't seem to keep her mouth shut. If there was a microphone around she would find it, and she was always ready with a juicy quote to share regarding the 'former champion.' The torment seemed to drag on and on... mostly because Cole refused to let it die.

But through it all, the only question the women of RSI asked was what could they do to help? Danni had done so much for each of them over the years, and now they stood ready to do whatever was needed. She didn't make it easy for them, but her teammates refused to be denied... and they quickly discovered the way to help her was to use her generous nature against her. Suddenly, everybody needed Danni's help. Everyone was eager for a slice of her time. And once they got their hooks in, they turned it all around on her. Using the sessions to ignite a little

friendly competition. To push her and challenge her and hit her with everything they had. Doing whatever they could to sharpen her and make sure she was ready.

The end result? An unbelievable tournament run where she faced down one talented opponent after another... and made it look incredibly easy. And waiting for her in the final? None other than the very chatty Cheryl Cole. I won't lie. My heart was in my throat before that fight started because I knew Danni's entire career was on the line that night. Both fighters had beaten some of the best to get there. Both were clearly in shape and on top of their game. If Cheryl beat her up again... there would no longer be any doubt about which of them was better.

Turned out my worrying was a waste of time. Danni didn't just win the fight. She blew Cole out of the cage. A total victory that ended all talk of her demise and stuck a giant cork in Cheryl's mouth. Cole spends all her time trying to avoid the media now... because she's tired of answering those same questions Danni had so recently been forced to face.

Will there be a rubber match? Most definitely. Cole still has the divisional belt, and - though I've never heard her say it - I know Danni wants it back. Bad.

Am I worried? Nope. When she's ready and focused, Danni is the better fighter by a mile. And I will never let her go into that cage unprepared again. Neither will her teammates. She can resist us all she wants, but it won't be any use. Because we know her secret, now. After all, she knew what we were doing before the tournament. Probably knew it from the very start. But she let it continue. Putting up with it for the simplest of reasons.

I hugged her a little tighter.

"You can't lie to me, Harris," I said. "Watson already blew your cover."

"Oh, yeah? How's that?"

"She made me see how rare it is for you to really enjoy yourself on the training floor," I said. "She said you never get to just be 'one of the girls.'"

"Just cause Emma said it..."

"Don't even bother," I cut in. "After she said it, I couldn't help watching you. You knew those girls were messing with you, but you still let them do it. And we both know you did it because you loved it."

She offered no denial.

"So this is Emma's fault," she said with a sigh.

"Tell me she's wrong."

Again, no answer.

"And there you have it," I concluded.

She shook her head lightly, and a little smile creased her lips. Her way of admitting I'd scored a point in the never-ending tennis match that is our relationship.

I stepped around to face her, looping my arms around her waist and...

"I believe your hands are on my ass," she said.

"Indeed, I believe that is correct."

"You need to remove them."

"Why would I do that?" I said. "I mean, it's such a fine ass."

"Be that as it may, I can't have you grabbing it while we're arguing."

"First of all, *grabbing* is a very crude term. I think *caressing* would be more appropriate."

"Uh, huh..."

"And second, I really don't see the need to continue this disagreement. I'm right. You know I'm right. So, let's just agree on that, and move on."

"But alas... it's not that simple."

"Of course not. Why would it be?"

I leaned in close and nibbled her ear.

"Mmmmm... now you're just cheating," she said.

And now you know why I'm getting dressed in Danni's bedroom. You also know the biggest reason I've been so happy lately.

After years of working side-by-side - years that have taken us through more heartbreak, disaster and triumph than I can say - the two of us have finally figured out what everybody else seemed to know all along. That we are much more than co-workers, and much more than friends. We are in love. Deeply and completely.

I can see now why it was so obvious to everyone. No matter the situation, Danni is the first person I want beside me. I can count on her for anything, and I trust her more than I trust myself. It makes perfect sense that a bond that strong would evolve into a relationship like this. But that didn't stop us from fighting it all the way. And when I say us, I mean me. Jesus... what an ass I was.

The fact that it all worked out might be the greatest proof of what we have together. I wasn't able to screw it up, no matter how hard I tried. It was almost like the universe wouldn't let me.

She turned to face me, and - for just a moment - time stood still. I knew those beautiful, piercing brown eyes should scare me. That they could see things others could not. I sometimes wondered just how deep into my soul she could look. Did she know about the hollow spaces? The holes and missing pieces I had long hidden and even forgotten about? Did she understand how she had helped fill them?

We kissed, and a warm tingle spread through me. A strange mix of desire, safety and peace. All I wanted was to crawl back under the covers with her.

Danni - knowing just how to toy with me - let the kiss go on long enough to rouse the now familiar hunger in my chest. Then she gently forced me back.

"We have to get to work," she said.

I didn't want to stop. My body ached for more of her. But she was right, and I knew it. It wasn't just about maybe being late. If we gave in to this, we were unlikely to ever get out the door.

I kissed her again.

"To be continued?" I asked.

"Count on it," she smiled.

Like I said, life is good.

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We managed to keep our hands off each other long enough to get going, but it also allowed us to resume the earlier bickering. Luckily the trip to RSI was short... but the conversation continued even after our arrival.

"I still don't understand what you're trying to do," she said as she followed me into my office. "How does having me on the training floor more change anything? What are you expecting me to do?"

"First of all, I freely admit I don't know what I'm doing on this."

"There's a surprise."

"Second, I don't expect you to do anything," I said. "Just be you and do your thing."

"And?"

"And nothing," I answered.

I took my seat. Danni took a guest chair. We sat and stared at each other for a while. I picked a little blue stress ball up of the desk and rolled it in my right hand as I let her think things over.

"I'm not following your logic," she said eventually.

"That's because there's not much logic to it."

"There's a..."

"Shut it," I interrupted.

We stared some more.

"Look," I said, "neither of us knows the recipe for what happened. That's because we didn't do the cooking. They did."

I gestured toward the wall behind her and the training floor beyond that would soon be brought to life by the women of RSI.

"All I'm trying to do is make sure they have the ingredients they need," I continued. "What they do from there is up to them."

By now, I knew she understood what I was getting at. It really wasn't that complicated. But she couldn't just instantly stop being a pain in my ass. The nature of our relationship required that she get the last word in a case like this.

"So, basically, you're going for a plan that's just half-assed enough to work?"

I tossed the ball at her - my aim dead on for a shot between the eyes. She avoided it easily with a casual shift of her head, and it glanced off the back of her chair and slowly bounced along toward the open door. I sighed, thinking now I was going to have to get up and go fetch it, but then it ricocheted off Steph's leg as she walked in.

"Oooooohhh... kick save, McMahon!" I shouted.

She had no reaction. I turned to Danni.

"She doesn't seem impressed by my limited hockey knowledge."

"Or any other area of your limited knowledge, for that matter."

"You know, your ass may be fine, but I will still kick it."

"Or try, at least."

Love... MMA style.

I looked to Steph to see what she thought of all this. I didn't expect to learn much. Her standard expression is best described as stony indifference... but I quickly realized something was off. She seemed colder and more distant than usual, and there was a touch of what might have been sadness.

I straightened up immediately. Danni saw the change, followed my gaze to Steph, then quickly sobered up, as well.

"What's wrong?" I asked.

Her face got sadder. Because she already regretted what she was going to say.

"Demi's no-call, no-show."

I glanced at Danni, then we both looked back to Steph. The air was suddenly thick with tension. This was not the first time Demi Lovato had gone missing, and past occurrences had never ended well.

"You tried calling?" Danni asked.

Steph nodded.

"Emily, Tiz, Aly," I said, "nobody knows anything?"

As the most accomplished member of our lightweight group, Emily served as a mentor and frequent sparring partner for Demi. Tiz and Aly were the RSI athletes she was closest to... probably because they'd all followed a similar path to get where they were in life.

Steph shook her head solemnly.

We looked at each other some more. All of us wondering where this was headed. Would it be the same as before, or would it finally be something worse?

I knew this much. None of us believed it would turn out to be nothing.

"I'll call her agent," I sighed.

"I'll start checking the media sites," Danni said.

She headed over to her own office, while Steph went back to the business of getting the women of RSI ready for battle.

I hadn't even dug up the agent's number before Danni was back.

"I sent you an email," she said.

I checked and found a message addressed to Steph and myself. The body contained nothing but a link to an article on the *TMZ* website.

A cesspool of ugly rumor and tawdry celebrity gossip, the site is roundly despised around here... but the information is usually reliable.

I clicked the link and the headline appeared in huge, bold type.

Demi Lovato Suffers Drug Overdose, 'Awake and Responsive' in Hospital

I scanned through the article. The dateline showed the story was only an hour old. The details registered as a jumble of misery.

Police were called...

...treated with Narcan...

...still unconscious when paramedics arrived...

...love, prayers and support...

"Son of a bitch," I mumbled.

I was upset and angry... and yet I couldn't help feeling a sense of relief. As bad as this was, it still wasn't the worst outcome you imagine when you're dealing with an addict.

I sat back and stared absently at my desk... thinking the same illogical thought everyone thinks in a moment like this.

God dammit, Demi... how could you do this?

Like coming within inches of dying was something she'd planned when she got up yesterday.

"What do you want to do?" Danni asked.

"Do?" I asked, thinking, *She's an addict. There's nothing anyone can do.*

"She's on the card in two weeks," she clarified.

I dropped my head into my hands and rubbed my eyes with my palms. The RSI-related impact of this seemed impossibly trivial, but at least it was something we could do... and the sooner, the better. Demi was already going to have enough PR problems. If we handled our stuff quickly, it could get lost in the noise.

"Pull her," I said.

"That it?" she asked, wondering whether we should go the next step and take Demi off the active roster entirely.

"For now," I said.

We shared a long look. Both of us knew I was only delaying the inevitable. Demi was going to have to be suspended. The road back from this was going to be long, physically and emotionally. It would probably be months before she was ready to even think about returning to training. Who knows when she would be in any shape to actually fight?

But neither of us said another word. Mired in a shared sadness we couldn't do anything about.

She eventually went to make her calls while I went back to looking up the agent's number. He would need to be kept in the loop about what we were doing, even if it was just a formality.

After a moment or two, I stopped and stared at the desk some more.

The shift in my mood was total. I had been so happy just a half hour ago. But that's the thing about happiness.

It is so easily lost.